Opening Log Cards

A friendly getting-started guide

You do not need to memorize twenty moves of theory. You need one place that remembers which openings you actually played, what you were going for, and how it turned out. These cards are that place: one card per opening, filled in pencil, updated after every game.

How to use it

1. **Cut the cards out** along the dashed lines. They fit in the front pocket of most chess bags, journals, and scorebooks.
2. **One card per opening.** “Italian Game”, “London System”, “Caro-Kann Defense” — whatever you keep meeting.
3. **Record the main line as you know it** — the first five to ten moves is plenty. When a game branches off, add the method you were missing.
4. **Update the tally after every game.** The W–D–L row is the honest report card: three losses in a row with an opening is real information.
5. **Verdict column:** keep, tweak, or benched — then write one line on why. Your future self will thank you.

Pencils only. Openings get revised as you improve — a pencil takes the revision gracefully, an eraser is part of the process.

Beginner tip: When you lose with an opening, the mistake is usually not on move six. Note the first move you did not understand — that is the exact spot your next lesson or reference session should cover.

Opening Log Card 1

Opening: _____ ECO code: _____

Sounds like: _____

Main line as I know it:

_____

_____

_____

What it's aiming for: _____

The trap / surprise to watch: _____

Games with it: W _____ D _____ L _____

Verdict: ☐ keep ☐ tweak ☐ benched because: _____

Opening Log Card 2

Opening: _____ ECO code: _____

Sounds like: _____

Main line as I know it:

_____

_____

_____

What it's aiming for: _____

The trap / surprise to watch: _____

Games with it: W _____ D _____ L _____

Verdict: ☐ keep ☐ tweak ☐ benched because: _____

Pencils only — no pens near the board. Three more cards overleaf: print extra copies as your repertoire grows.

Opening Log Card 3

Opening: _____ ECO code: _____

Sounds like: _____

Main line as I know it:

_____

_____

_____

What it's aiming for: _____

The trap / surprise to watch: _____

Games with it: W _____ D _____ L _____

Verdict: ☐ keep ☐ tweak ☐ benched because: _____

Opening Log Card 4

Opening: _____ ECO code: _____

Sounds like: _____

Main line as I know it:

_____

_____

_____

What it's aiming for: _____

The trap / surprise to watch: _____

Games with it: W _____ D _____ L _____

Verdict: ☐ keep ☐ tweak ☐ benched because: _____

Pencils only — no pens near the board. "Sounds like" is your plain-English reminder of the plan, not a chess term — e.g. "slow build, pawn triangle, queenside spark."